

How preexisting beliefs and message involvement drive charitable donations: an integrated model

Preexisting
beliefs

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to investigate how individuals respond to messages asking for donations in broadcast advertising. It does so by considering both preexisting attitudes and beliefs related to donating, as well as message processing. The goal is to uncover messages that may help nonprofit organisations increase donations.

Design/methodology/approach – The research combines the theory of planned behaviour (TPB) to measure preexisting beliefs and the elaboration likelihood model (ELM) to measure involvement in an investigation of donation responses to broadcast-quality advertisements developed by a professional ad agency featuring the following two messages: one that leverages social norms and another that legitimises minimal giving. Two studies collected data from a total of 544 respondents in two between-subjects $2 \times 2 \times 2$ experiments.

Findings – Injunctive norm messages affect the intended donation behaviour of individuals who are pre-disposed to donating, but only if they are highly involved with the ad. Social legitimisation messages affect donations from individuals who look to referents to direct behaviour, but unlike what was expected, only by those not highly involved with the ad. Similarly, individuals who do not think they can donate increased donations when they saw the legitimisation message and had low advertisement involvement.

Research limitations/implications – Results extend the ELM-TPB integrated framework by discovering when and how involvement drives intended donation behaviour. The research also sheds light on message processing by focussing on the preexisting characteristics of recipients.

Practical implications – The results provide nonprofit managers with strategies to increase donations with targeted messages. Those who pay attention to the ad and have a positive attitude toward giving are going to donate if they are told others support the cause. Therefore, the focus should be on those who are not involved with the ad but still believe giving is appropriate.

Originality/value – This research is the first to use the ELM-TPB framework to discover that ELM has varying utilities and values from TPB in different ad contexts.

Keywords Nonprofit, Donations, Advertising, Cause marketing, Theory of planned behaviour, Elaboration likelihood model

Paper type Research paper



Introduction

To be effective, nonprofit marketing managers must attract new donors and retain old ones by implementing marketing communications strategies that are designed to change

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attitudes and beliefs in the hope of enhancing donations (Kogut and Ritov, 2011; Ratner *et al.*, 2011). The challenge for most nonprofit organisations (NPOs) is to develop effective persuasive messages that inform, educate and convince recipients to act (Bendapudi *et al.*, 1996; Cole *et al.*, 2016; Summers and Summers, 2017). Prior research has added to our understanding of these efforts through the impact of diverse elements of the marketing mix (Beale and Bosnal, 2006; Boer and Westhoff, 2006; Hill and Abraham, 2008), while other research has tested specific components of nonprofit advertisements such as leveraging emotions (Choi *et al.*, 2016; Erlandsson *et al.*, 2018; Genevsky and Knutson, 2015; Moriuchi and Chung, 2018), storytelling (Merchant *et al.*, 2010; Small, 2011) and providing specific information about the individual in need (Kogut and Ritov, 2011; Small and Verrochi, 2009; Summers and Summers, 2017). Despite this, few studies examine nonprofit advertising and the messages used that specifically ask for money (Hong and Lee, 2018), exposing a potential gap in the research. Then fewer still have focussed specifically on affecting donations using communication messages in broadcast-style ads. This research attempts to fill that gap.

For NPOs, it is imperative to understand how message content can influence someone to act (Sargeant, 2014; Summers and Summers, 2017). The integration of the theory of planned behaviour (TPB) and the elaboration likelihood model (ELM) can help explain how this can be achieved because beliefs, attitudes and intentions can help determine whether a message has its desired effects (Rucker and Petty, 2006). Both theories are applicable to research in nonprofit contexts because each attempts to explain how beliefs and attitudes can affect behaviour. However, while ELM is often used to examine message processing, “many studies do not include the intention-adoption link in their model even though their underlying assumptions are based on the theory of planned behaviour”, (Goh *et al.*, 2017, p. 14). In fact, it is argued that the flaw in ELM is that it fails to test the links between changes in attitude and changes in behaviour and that TPB fills that gap (Wilson, 2014). Further, integrating theories is important as combining two theories can address what neither can do independently (Mayer and Sparrowe, 2013).

To advance our understanding of the issues related to the effectiveness of donation messages in broadcast advertisements, the present study combines precepts from TPB and ELM to investigate donation responses to two types of messages, the first featuring social normative messages and the second communicating social legitimisation. To date, ELM and TPB have not been examined in tandem in an experimental design-based study to explain behavioural intention through exposure to advertising messages despite the fact that the combination can offer insight into the effectiveness of messaging (Wilson, 2014). Efforts have been made to combine TPB with ELM to leverage the dual-processing routes of the ELM framework while integrating TPB's decision-making path (Brown *et al.*, 2010; Prochaska and DiClemente, 1983; Teng *et al.*, 2015; Valois *et al.*, 2001). However, none of these specifically researched messages in advertising, nor did they explore the interactive effects of involvement with the ad and the TPB antecedents to behavioural intention, nor did any do so within the context of cause marketing – defined as the marketing of nonprofit, political or social efforts (Dann *et al.*, 2007). The present research does all three. Specifically, the three TPB antecedents of attitude toward the behaviour (i.e. donating to a cause or ATB), subjective norms (what referent groups are doing or SN) and perceived behavioural control (ability to comply with the message request for a donation or PBC) are tested to see if they influence donation responses to NPO ads depending upon the level of involvement with the ad.

In doing so, the present research contributes to theory and marketing management in the following ways. Firstly, it applies ELM to combine the literature on prosocial causes, media

presentation and giving opportunities to explain how individuals behave differently based on level of involvement (Chang and Lee, 2010). Secondly, it extends the ELM-TPB integrated framework by discovering key results including that ELM has varying utilities and values from TPB in different ad contexts. Thirdly, the research relies on TPB to respond to the call for investigations into the identification of factors such as consumer traits and campaign structural elements that may impact consumer involvement in cause marketing campaigns and ultimately influence process mechanisms responsible for behaviour (Grau and Folse, 2007). Finally, the study responds to the call by Tangari *et al.* (2010) for investigations testing the effects of ad processing and message framing on self-regulation, which argues that consumers use internal and external cues to affect behaviour, particularly in situations where they consider the expected behaviour of others (Bandura, 1986, 1991).

Donation marketing research review

Donating is consumer behaviour and NPOs can benefit from knowing what affects donor motivations. That is why researchers and practitioners need to understand the implications of various underlying processes to develop campaigns and programmes that translate into long-term behavioural changes (Smith *et al.*, 1994). In addition, NPOs not only need to persuade individuals to defer spending their money on consumer goods and leisure activities but also must persuade individuals to direct their contribution to a specific NPO (Strahilevitz, 2011).

Factors that affect one's inclination to donate to a nonprofit organisation include:

- motivations such as altruism, empathy and guilt;
- social norms;
- socio-economics, financial ability and past giving history; and
- message delivery features such as framing and content (Sargeant, 2014).

Emotions appear to play one of the most important roles in the donor-NPO relationship. For example, previous research found the reaction to a nonprofit advertisement was strongly affected by processing motivation and preexisting attitudes, with positive emotions producing stronger reactions to nonprofit advertisements than negative emotions (Randle *et al.*, 2016). In fact, ads that elicit negative emotions often lead to negative outcomes such as decreased reaction to the ad. When testing emotional versus rational appeals, Chen *et al.* (2016) found that emotional message frames were more effective, with guilt appeals the most effective. It is also important to develop trust and commitment between the donor and the NPO, as previous research shows it is related to giving behaviour (Sargeant and Lee, 2004). Playing on the emotional benefits of prosocial behaviour does increase donations, but informing potential donors that giving makes people happy does not because that type of information acts only as an incentive, and therefore affects just short-term giving (Anik *et al.*, 2011). Prosocial behaviour can also be driven simply by the need to shape self-identity as someone who helps others (Wilson and Musick, 1997), which can motivate individuals to donate. Other research has found that donations can increase if nonprofits offer donors opportunities to make regular, smaller donations rather than one large donation once, a strategy that also affects the relationship between how much a donor gives and how good they feel about donating (Strahilevitz, 2011).

Research has also found that donors read signs and the effect of the signs is due to the message on the sign rather than simply the sign's presence (Martin and Randal, 2011). However, message differences did not factor into donation amount. The amount people give also is not based on the amount of a number of individuals in need, nor how efficiently

donated funds are spent by the NPO asking for the contribution (Oppenheimer and Olivola, 2011). In fact, individuals prefer to donate to a single, identified victim rather than to a group of victims (Kogut and Ritov, 2011). This has led some to wonder whether social norms play a significant role in donation behaviour. In that vein, Croson and Shang (2011) found the size of a potential donation is influenced by the size of a previous contributor's donation and the impact is affected by the perceived similarities of the donor to the individual who gave just before them.

However, the perception of social norms has been shown to be negatively correlated with an individual's relation to the NPO (Shang and Sargeant, 2016). In addition, the norm of self-interest, in which people feel it is only important to donate when the cause is of personal interest, keeps some people from giving (Ratner *et al.*, 2011). In research on crowdfunding, there was no difference in appeals that featured a self-benefit or others-benefit (Chen *et al.*, 2016). Still, it seems that donation decisions more often than not depend on the salience of the beneficiary (Cryder and Loewenstein, 2011) as other-benefit appeals performed better than self-benefit appeals when the beneficiaries were part of the in-group but not the out-group (Park and Lee, 2015). In the case of the latter, donations actually decreased. In addition, the level of interest, compassion and surprise have positive effects on behavioural intention when individuals were shown different types of nonprofit advertising appeals (Cockrill and Parsonage, 2016) while leveraging communal messaging can also increase donations in a political context (Kaikati *et al.*, 2017).

Specifically, in the context of TPB, efforts have been made to better understand the link between marketing elements and donor behaviour through the use of leaflets (Beale and Bosnal, 2006; Hill and Abraham, 2008), social networking (Boer and Westhoff, 2006), word of mouth (Wann-Yih *et al.*, 2009) and a full campaign (Stead *et al.*, 2005), with results showing that marketing messages have an effect on attitudes and behaviours toward a cause. Strategies such as soliciting feedback, providing updates and offering value to donors (such as through a participatory fundraising event) have also proven to improve donations and long-term donor relationships (Strahilevitz, 2011).

Conceptual framework

Theory of planned behaviour and persuasion

The TPB is a valuable model used by researchers to predict behavioural intention, which is considered a summation of the motivations necessary to perform a specific behaviour (Armitage and Christian, 2004) and has demonstrated to be effective in predicting consumer behaviour or more specifically, the intentions of the individual (Ajzen, 1991). For this reason, the TPB has been found to be better at predicting behaviour than models that measure just attitudes (Armitage and Christian, 2004).

TPB relies on direct measures of attitudes and when desirable (Ajzen, 1991), indirect measures of beliefs to predict behavioural intention, which is significantly related to behaviour. TPB contains three constructs that predict intentions:

- (1) attitude toward the behaviour;
- (2) subjective norms (the perceived social pressure to perform or not to perform the behaviour); and
- (3) perceived behavioural control (the belief in one's ability to perform the behaviour).

The importance of each construct varies across situations and between individuals (Ajzen, 1991). That is, in some studies, only one construct may be strongly related to intention. It could also be that two of the three are significant, while sometimes it is all three. In sum,

TPB has shown that individuals consider the consequences of the behaviour, evaluate what they believe others expect them to do and weigh whether or not they believe they have the ability to adopt that behaviour.

There has been extensive empirical support for the effectiveness of TPB in predicting intention and behaviour. A meta-analysis conducted by [Armitage and Conner \(2001\)](#) of 185 studies found TPB accounted for 39% of the variance for intention and 27% of the variance for behaviour. Still, some research has demonstrated flaws with the TPB, ranging from poor operational definitions of attitudes, subjective norms, perceived behavioural control and their outcomes ([Gagné and Godin, 2000](#)) making it impossible to develop hypotheses ([Ogden, 2003](#)), to various constructs within the model failing to predict either outcome ([Bagozzi and Kimmel, 1995](#); [Sideridis et al., 1998](#)).

When leveraging TPB, persuasive communications designed to influence a belief about an object produce changes in attitudes toward the object. Messages directed toward normative beliefs can influence subjective norms, while those directed toward control beliefs can influence perceived behavioural control ([Maddock et al., 2008](#); [Stead et al., 2005](#)). Studies on persuasive communications have relied on the TPB framework, including promotion leaflets designed to stimulate beliefs about condom use, campaigns to educate about the dangers of speeding and messages regarding exercise or healthy food ([Hill and Abraham, 2008](#); [Maddock et al., 2008](#); [Stead et al., 2005](#)).

Persuasive messages and TPB have also been examined in combination in studies related to cause marketing. For example, research on green marketing ([ShabbirHusain and Varshney, 2019](#)); suicide interventions ([Shemanski Aldrich and Cerel, 2009](#)) and healthy eating ([Tsorbatzoudis, 2005](#)) have examined attitudes and beliefs. More recently, [Erlandsson et al. \(2018\)](#) examined attitudes in relation to appeals that had either positive or negative messaging, finding that positive appeals are better at creating favourable attitudes toward the NPO and the ad, but that negative appeals lead to more donations.

Elaboration likelihood and message processing

Decision-making is one of the foundations of consumer behaviour and provides an avenue for persuasive communications to affect beliefs, attitudes and behaviours ([Barden and Petty, 2008](#); [Petty et al., 1983](#)). One of the most reliable models in understanding how persuasion works within the decision-making process is the ELM ([Teng et al., 2015](#)). ELM assumes that individuals process persuasive information differently ([Petty and Cacioppo, 1984](#)) with that processing beginning the moment they receive a message, such as through an advertisement. As soon as the message is received, the individual attempts to relate the information to any preexisting beliefs they have about the issue ([Cialdini et al., 1981](#)). Messages are more persuasive when they support these beliefs.

ELM research has shown that beliefs, attitudes and behaviour can change based on how well cognitive responses align with a message being communicated ([Petty et al., 1983](#)). In ELM, individuals process persuasive information differently ([Petty and Cacioppo, 1984](#)), with processing beginning the moment they receive a message. Processing proceeds upon one of two routes – central or peripheral – depending on factors such as message content, inherent traits of the consumer and the situation in which the consumer finds themselves ([Cialdini et al., 1981](#)). Individuals follow the central route to persuasion when high-involvement information processing takes place, meaning that the individual is motivated to expend cognitive effort on the message. The peripheral route is followed when a consumer is engaged in low-involvement information processing when motivation and ability are low ([Cialdini et al., 1981](#)) where involvement is defined as the personal relevance of the information ([Mowen and Minor, 2006](#)).

In challenging ELM, some researchers suggest a single route for processing persuasive communications because, they argue, motivation and cognition are impacted similarly no matter how the individual processes the message (Kruglanski and Thompson, 1999). But ELM argues that individuals do process messages differently and that the central and peripheral routes are capable of explaining processing of both message and non-message variables, as well as when motivation is high and low (Petty *et al.*, 1999). Therefore, ELM may provide a more robust model of message processing than the proposed unimodal.

ELM has been extended in terms of antecedents, including engagement with advertisements (Wang, 2006), need for cognition (Tam and Ho, 2005), cultural orientation (Luo *et al.*, 2014), expertise and involvement (Sussman and Siegal, 2003), job relevance (Bhattacharjee and Sanford, 2006) and mobile app privacy (Gu *et al.*, 2017). For its part, TPB's antecedents are relevant influences that precede downstream attitudes toward donating to NPOs. For example, individuals have preexisting beliefs toward donating (attitude toward the behaviour) and assess their ability to comply with the request when confronted with a persuasive message asking for some contribution (perceived behavioural control), while also considering whether or not referent groups are important to the behaviour would approve or disapprove of the behaviour (subjective norms). However, individuals with varying preexisting beliefs about donating also have different levels of involvement with NPO messages.

An integrated ELM-TPB model

There has been debate on whether researchers working on persuasion theories should focus on just one process or combine multiple processes together (Petty *et al.*, 1999). According to Ajzen (1991), efforts should be made to develop alternative models that could better describe the relations between beliefs and constructs. The TPB "is open to the inclusion of additional predictors if it can be shown that they capture a significant proportion of the variance in intention or behaviour" after the variables within the theory are taken into account (Ajzen, 1991, p. 199). Researchers have taken these words to heart and have developed various integrated models incorporating TPB and multiple theories.

For example, one early study paired TPB and ELM with the transtheoretical change model that identifies various degrees of motivation leading toward change (Prochaska and DiClemente, 1983) with results showing that attitude could predict the level of processing for messages related to exercise (Rosen, 2000). In another study, researchers integrated TPB with a model developed by the World Health Organisation on the international classification of functioning disability and health (Bonetti and Johnston, 2008). Results showed significance for the predictiveness of perceived behavioural control and self-efficacy on intention and behaviour. TPB was also tested in conjunction with the spiral of silence theory to determine social influence, finding significance for peer influence on opinion expression behaviour and marginal significance for the perception of majority attitude particularly that of peers (Neuwirth and Frederick, 2004).

In investigating the possibilities of incorporating TPB into a dual-process model of attitude-behaviour relationships, Conner and Armitage (1998) posited that attitude toward the behaviour may predict intention and behaviour when individuals are both motivated and have the opportunity (high perceived behavioural control). But when one or the other is low, attitude toward the behaviour may either diminish the probability of the behaviour even happening or may make the behaviour more spontaneous. Therefore, incorporating a dual-process model like ELM should provide a more comprehensive model for understanding the attitude-behaviour relationship (Conner and Armitage, 1998). They call

for more research to determine what processes influence the factors of TPB and what factors of TPB influence other processes.

In an early effort to evaluate the combined effects of persuasive messages and behavioural intention, researchers found a significant relationship between exposure to the message and self-reported self-examination for cancer on both behaviour and intention (Brubaker and Fowler, 1990). Afterwards, TPB and ELM were integrated to verify the effect of persuasive messages on beliefs, attitudes and intentions regarding nursing care (Valois *et al.*, 2001), demonstrating that such messages could change beliefs and attitudes among nursing students who had to provide care for people living with HIV/AIDS. More recently, the two theories have been integrated using structural equation modelling to improve the predictive ability of behavioural intention in tourists (Meng and Choi, 2019) verifying the moderating role of involvement through ELM, as well as predicting the intention to use electronic word-of-mouth (Wang, 2015). A third study using SEM also found that elaboration predicted the components of TPB (Miller *et al.*, 2019) with some components of TPB functioning as a mediator between elaboration and behavioural intention.

Still, ELM and TPB have not been examined in tandem in an experimental design-based marketing study to explain effects on behavioural intention through exposure to advertising messages. At best, research has demonstrated that individuals approach a specific topic with pre-determined beliefs that, when combined with their innate message processing abilities, can affect change in behaviour. Research in this area has focussed on attitudes and beliefs in such topics as affirmative action (White *et al.*, 2008), organ donation (Bae, 2008; Reid and Wood, 2008), e-commerce (Lim and Dubinsky, 2005), exercise (Boer and Westhoff, 2006; Jones *et al.*, 2004; Maddock *et al.*, 2008; Rosen, 2000), healthy eating (Chan and Tsang, 2011) and transportation options (Beale and Bosnal, 2006; Stead *et al.*, 2005).

Investigating TPB with ELM contributes to the field by testing the links between changes in attitude and changes in behaviour (Wilson, 2014). Likewise, the integration of TPB with ELM adds to our understanding of how antecedent individual factors, such as those expressed in TPB, influence responses to NPO ads, depending upon the level of involvement with the ad. Because ELM has demonstrated that individuals process messages through two routes (central and peripheral) related to involvement and because the reaction to a nonprofit ad are strongly affected by preexisting attitudes and processing motivation (Randle *et al.*, 2016), it is believed:

- the preexisting beliefs held by the individual, integrated with;
- the type of persuasive message to which the viewer is exposed; and
- the viewer's message processing measured as one's involvement with the advertisement, will shape behavioural intention.

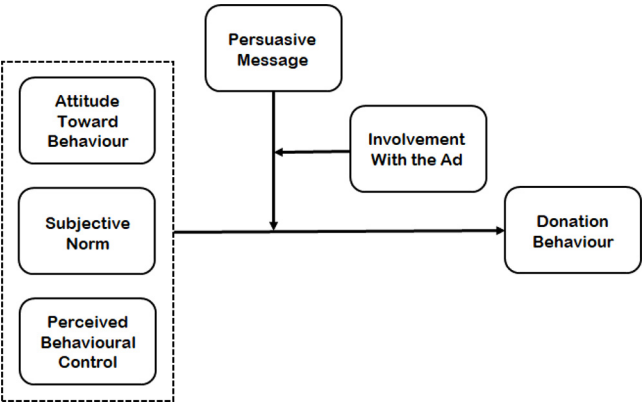
Taking this into account and following previous research that investigated the interactive effects of three variables on a dependent variable (Merlo and Augh, 2009), a model integrating TPB and ELM to predict intended donation behaviour is proposed (Figure 1).

Hypothesis development

Social normative messages

Individuals may support NPOs for reasons including social norms, religious convictions and personal relevance (Kogut and Ritov, 2011; Ratner *et al.*, 2011). Social norms can predict a positive relationship between donation size and the perceived average size of previous donations, with average donation per individual sensitive to whether or not others have given in the past (Martin and Randal, 2011). While some donation research has revealed that

Figure 1.
Integrated model
depicting three-way
interaction on
donation behaviour



perceptions of social norms do not correlate with how donors feel about the importance of their donor identity nor the NPO they support (Shang and Sargeant, 2016), others argue that social norms should be included in all models of predictive behaviour related to donations (Bennett and Vijaygopal, 2019). Previous research shows persuasive messages that contain information about others' giving can influence an individual's donations (Croson and Shang, 2011; Shang and Croson, 2008), while similar messages indicating that others did, versus did not support the charitable organisations also positively influenced behavioural intention (Cao, 2018). In addition, the more similarities that exist between the potential donor and the previous donor to which the persuasive message is referring, the more impactful the information about the previous donor is to the potential donor (Shang *et al.*, 2008).

In research specifically examining the intention to donate, three types of social normative messaging – descriptive, injunctive and moral – have been evaluated to determine which would be most effective in predicting behavioural intention (Smith and McSweeney, 2007). Descriptive norms are what individuals believe is typically done in a given situation or what they think most people do, while injunctive norms are behaviours that individuals believe are approved by society or what people think they *should* do (Cialdini *et al.*, 1990). Moral norms, however, are not related to social pressure, but instead are an individual's internal rules for living and personal feelings of responsibility (Smith and McSweeney, 2007). In examining the effects of injunctive and descriptive norms, Smith and Louis (2008) informed participants that a proportion of the people *approve* of the behaviour (e.g. 73% for high approval and 29% for low approval) to test injunctive norms and used the same proportions to describe how many people *participated* in the behaviour (73% performance versus 29% performance) to test descriptive norms.

While previous research (Slovic, 2007; Small *et al.*, 2007) has found that providing statistics can inhibit giving because the statistics make potential donors consider the information analytically rather than emotionally – which has proven to be effective in motivating donors (Anik *et al.*, 2011; Kogut and Ritov, 2011; Small, 2011) – the methodology used by Smith and Louis (2008) was based on the group-norm approach to social identity, where perceived norms of a group in which an individual identifies himself or herself have a significant effect on behavioural intentions. Therefore, if individuals have a positive attitude toward the behaviour, the relationship between attitude and behaviour will be strong if they perceive the behaviour is supported by the referent group and weak if they perceive the opposite.

In addition, persuasion can produce changes in attitude that have a duration related to the amount of processing (i.e. involvement with the ad) extended by the individual (Cialdini *et al.*, 1981). As a result, it is expected that the combination of preexisting attitudes and beliefs, integrated with involvement and the type of message, will have an effect on donation behaviour (i.e. donation intention and the donation amount). Therefore, there will be a three-way interaction between involvement with the advertisement, persuasive normative messages and each measure of TPB on donation behaviour. While evidence from previous research indicates injunctive and descriptive norms can have an effect on attitudes, intentions and behaviour (Albrecht *et al.*, 2017; Manning, 2011; Warburton and Terry, 2000), the effect is also relative to the level of normative support (Shang and Croson, 2008, 2009; Smith and Louis, 2008). That is, the more support for the behaviour as communicated through the message, the greater the effect of the message, creating the three-way interaction. However, when normative messaging is in a low condition, it is expected one's involvement with the ad will be the primary driver of intention, creating a main effect. Thus:

- H1a. The moderating effect of high normative messaging on the relationship between *attitude toward the behaviour* and donation intention will be greater at high (vs low) levels of involvement with the ad.
- H1b. The moderating effect of high normative messaging on the relationship between *subjective norms* and donation intention will be greater at high (vs low) levels of involvement with the ad.
- H1c. The moderating effect of high normative messaging on the relationship between *perceived behavioural control* and donation intention will be greater at high (vs low) levels of involvement with the ad.

Social legitimisation messages

Behavioural influence relies on strong normative behaviour to cause individuals to comply with a request. In the nonprofit industry, those tasked with fundraising may be better served by framing their solicitations as beneficial for the community rather than themselves (Sargeant, 2014). To this end, a messaging technique that has been proven effective in charitable giving situations is social legitimisation (Chen *et al.*, 2008; Shearman and Yoo, 2007). This social legitimisation of the minimum (SLM) is also known as the "even a penny" technique (Cialdini and Schroeder, 1976). It argues the legitimisation of small favours increases the likelihood that one will comply with the request because individuals have an innate desire to take actions that make them look good and will not want to be perceived negatively (Dibble *et al.*, 2011). When an individual is asked to perform some task and the request contains a phrase that indicates that others approve of making even a minimal effort, the total number of people responding favourably to the request increases compared to when the legitimisation of the minimum phrase is left out. In addition, when confronted with a small request, it is difficult for individuals to develop and/or defend a reason not to comply (Dibble *et al.*, 2011; Shearman and Yoo, 2007) making it difficult for the individual to escape looking like an unhelpful person (Dibble *et al.*, 2011).

Individuals conforming to social norms are influenced by evidence of numerous small donations, which cause actual donations to increase in frequency but be smaller on average per donor compared to conditions where the total amount is the same but the number of donations is less (Martin and Randal, 2011). If an NPO were to ask two different pools of potential donors to make contributions, the number of individuals who donate would be higher if the donation message included some form of minimal giving request. However, the

average donation amount per donor would be less than donations by individuals in the group that did not receive the message containing a request for a small gift (Cialdini and Schroeder, 1976). The challenge inherent within the strategy of simply making minimum requests is that while it leads to a higher percentage of compliant individuals, the outcome per individual is usually diminished from what it would be if such a minimum request was not made (Dibble *et al.*, 2011; Reeves and Saucer, 1993; Shearman and Yoo, 2007).

Because we know message processing through involvement affects behaviour, there should be a three-way interaction between involvement with an advertisement, social legitimisation messages and each measure of TPB on donation behaviour. Applying this to the previous predictions of an NPO asking for a donation, the group receiving the message containing SLM giving should have a higher percentage of individuals complying with the request than the group that does not receive such a message (Shearman and Yoo, 2007). Therefore, the three-way interaction should take place when social legitimisation messages are present. However, when such messages are absent, involvement with the ad is left as the driver of behaviour, thus producing a main effect based on the individual's level of involvement. As a result, the following is proposed:

- H2a. The moderating effect of social legitimisation messaging on the relationship between *attitude toward the behaviour* and donation intention will be greater at high (vs low) levels of involvement with the ad.
- H2b. The moderating effect of social legitimisation messaging on the relationship between *subjective norms* and donation intention will be greater at high (vs low) levels of involvement with the ad.
- H2c. The moderating effect of social legitimisation messaging on the relationship between *perceived behavioural control* and donation intention will be greater at high (vs low) levels of involvement with the ad.

Methodology

After determining the format and message options based on the content analysis of 125 existing NPO ads, a professional agency based in Texas named RD&F Advertising, a subsidiary of Ivie and Associates, developed different versions of a two-minute, broadcast-quality advertisement to conduct a pre-test on each potential manipulation. This is important because a key step in developing effective messages is comparing the desired message with a no-message control or with alternative messages (Rucker and Petty, 2006). Because previous experience with a particular NPO may act as a covariate in this research (Kidwell and Jewell, 2008), a fictitious nonprofit named the Better Cities Coalition – whose “mission” is to make cities more livable by improving infrastructure through the development of better block designs, bike routes and pedestrian zones – was created to “make” the contribution requests. This type of NPO is not uncommon in the USA, where governments often turn to the private sector to address issues the government cannot. Examples include the Rails to Trails Conservancy, the Better Block Foundation, the National Complete Streets Coalition, the Central Park Conservancy and numerous other organisations that work with governments in public-private partnerships on infrastructure planning.

In general, cause marketing ads that feature an emotional appeal are more persuasive (Moriuchi and Chung, 2018). Additionally, storytelling increases donations (Merchant *et al.*, 2010) and the best story that can be told to a prospective donor is to use a single, identifiable victim to arouse sympathy (Small, 2011). This works because people are more apt to make attributions about individuals than groups (Kogut and Ritov, 2011). In addition, portraying

a victim expressing sadness (Shim and Key, 2018; Small and Verrochi, 2009) and prior to receiving support from the viewer (Genevsky and Knutson, 2015) is the most effective and can lead to more donations (Choi *et al.*, 2016; Erlandsson *et al.*, 2018) because the potential donor watching the portrayal empathises with the victim, making them more likely to respond (Small, 2011; Summers and Summers, 2017). This is enhanced by providing more information about the individual, such as his or her name and photographs (Kogut and Ritov, 2011). In addition, in research that leveraged eye-tracking and electroencephalogram biometrics, images in NPO ads attracted the most attention (Alonso Dos Santos *et al.*, 2017), while it may not matter if a campaign uses positive or negative imagery (Chen *et al.*, 2016). Finally, donation campaigns leveraging sad expressions of a victim have greater effects on donations than when happy expressions are used (Pham and Septianto, 2020), though it can be better to expose the victim's helpless situation first followed by a positive outcome later (Shim and Key, 2018). Therefore, final versions of the advertisements focus on an affected individual named "Ricky" and show him in a highly emotive state and conclude by explaining the benefits to all those who live in the city in which the viewer lives, as appeals showing positive emotional benefits enhance donations (Moran and Bagchi, 2019).

A total of eight different broadcast ads were created, four each for the social normative manipulations and the social legitimisation manipulations. To test the normative manipulations, this research adopted Smith and Louis' (2008) conceptualisations of descriptive norms by indicating a percentage of participation rates (73% for high and 29% for low) and injunctive norms (using the same percentages) to describe approval of a behaviour. Social legitimisation messages were placed in the four other ads for the pre-test. They included the message "even a penny" in one ad because it has been used extensively in social legitimisation message manipulations (Andrews *et al.*, 2008), the message "even a dollar" in another because it was used in the original SLM research, the "for less than a dollar a day" message that emerged from the content analysis as the most commonly used donation request phrase was placed in a third ad and a control ad that features no social legitimisation message in the fourth (see Appendix 1 for ad spot scripts).

Data for the pre-test were collected via snowball sampling (Biernacki and Waldorf, 1981) in an online questionnaire distributed via email and social network sites. Because age has been shown to influence donations (O'Neil and Schenke, 2007; Peterson *et al.*, 2018; Yen, 2002), a screening question was asked to ensure participants were at least 21 years old. After eliminating respondents ($n = 75$) who either failed to complete the survey, did not follow directions or did not meet the age requirement, a final sample size of 235 (75.8%) was evaluated with a mean age of 49.5 ($SD = 16.28$) that was 53.6% male.

Manipulations for the injunctive norm advertisement were checked with items that read "Recalling the advertisement you saw, how would you rate the number of people who have donated to the Better Cities Coalition"? "Recalling the advertisement you saw, the amount of people who are supportive of donating to the Better Cities Coalition is high" and the reverse-coded "Based on the advertisement I saw, I have no idea how supportive people are of the Better Cities Coalition". The manipulations were analysed using a one-way ANOVA, finding a significant difference [$F(1, 80) = 5.168, p = 0.026$] between high and low injunctive normative manipulations, but no significance between high and low descriptive norms ($p = 0.740$). Therefore, the ads depicting high and low injunctive normative messages were chosen as the manipulation for the ensuing first study.

For the SLM manipulation, manipulation check items included "Recalling the advertisement you saw, a minimal amount can be donated to the Better Cities Coalition", "Recalling the advertisement you saw, it is OK to donate the bare minimum to the Better Cities Coalition" and the reverse-coded "Based on the advertisement you saw, making a

minimal donation to the Better Cities Coalition is not acceptable”. Analysis also showed significant differences [$F(1,51) = 6.211, p = 0.016$] between “even a penny” appeal and a control group that saw no message, as well as significance [$F(1,57), p = 0.020$] between “even a dollar” and the control group. There was no significance ($p = 0.167$) for the message “for less than a dollar a day”. That is, the phrase most often used in nonprofit advertising today to ask for donations has no significant difference in raising money than an ad that features no request at all. Therefore, because the “even a penny” manipulation was significant and because it has been used by research investigating SLM in the past (Andrews *et al.*, 2008), the ads communicating that message, along with the control group ad that had no SLM message, were used in Study 2 of the present research. However, an opportunity exists to test the “even a dollar” message in the future. A summary of which advertisements were used based on the results of the pre-tests can be found in Table 1.

Methods and measurement

Based on the results of the pre-test, Study 1 experimentally manipulated injunctive norm messages, as well as measured each of the TPB variables and measured involvement with the ad in a 2 (ATB/SN/PBC: high vs low) $\times$ 2 (injunctive norm: high vs low) $\times$ 2 (involvement: high vs low) between-subjects design. Because the ads were for an NPO involved with environmental issues, potential covariates attitude toward charitable organisations (Webb *et al.*, 2000) and environmental concern (Weigel and Weigel, 1978) were measured first to eliminate any potential confounds. Preexisting beliefs were measured next, with attitude toward the behaviour captured on an 11-item semantic differential scale, while social norms and perceived behavioural control were measured on four- and five-item scales, respectively (Fishbein and Ajzen, 2010). The injunctive norm manipulations leveraged in the pre-test (Smith and Louis, 2008) were then viewed by participants in the broadcast advertisement, followed by the two outcome variables – donation intention and donation amount. Donation intention was measured using a nine-item, seven-point semantic differential scale for behavioural intention (Fishbein and Ajzen, 2010), while donation amount was captured on a single-item scale that asked “If you were to make a donation to this nonprofit, how much would give”? This was followed by the measurement of involvement with an advertisement message via a six-item Likert-type scale (Cox and Cox, 2001). The instrument concluded with manipulation checks and demographic measures (see Appendix 2 for scales used).

The 39-item questionnaire was delivered online nationwide in the US on a one-time basis to participants via a US-based marketing research firm. Basic psychometric properties of the scales were examined using exploratory factor analysis and items with small loading or high cross-loading were removed (Appendix 3). This included one from the subjective norms

Table 1.
Results of pre-tests
for ads used

Ad number	Message type	Status
1	High injunctive social normative – “73% are supportive”	Used in Study 1
2	Low injunctive social normative – “29% are supportive”	Used in Study 1
3	High descriptive social normative – “73% have participated”	Not used
4	Low descriptive social normative – “29% have participated”	Not used
5	High social legitimisation – “Even a penny”	Used in Study 2
6	High social legitimisation – “Even a dollar”	Not used
7	High social legitimisation – “For less than a dollar a day”	Not used
8	No social legitimisation – Control ad	Used in Study 2

scale and one from the perceived behavioural control scale. All scales were evaluated for reliability using Cronbach's alpha, with each scale exceeding 0.70 minimums for reliability (Hair *et al.*, 2009). For example, the three planned behaviour scales – attitude toward the behaviour ($\alpha = 0.948$), subjective norms ($\alpha = 0.804$), perceived behavioural control ($\alpha = 0.813$) – proved reliable, as did donation intention ($\alpha = 0.962$) and involvement with the ad ($\alpha = 0.949$). The covariate measures, attitude toward charitable organisations ($\alpha = 0.886$) and environmental concern ($\alpha = 0.720$) were also reliable.

Results and analysis – Study 1

A total of 329 individuals participated in Study 1, with the survey software randomly and evenly distributing participants between the manipulations. From the total, 274 complete responses (83.3%) were used in the final analysis after removing invalid responses, with 52.2% ($n = 153$) viewing the high injunctive norm message and age ($M = 48.9$, $SD = 15.5$) and gender (52.4% male) similar to the pre-test subjects. A one-way ANOVA was used to evaluate the same manipulation questions used in the pre-test, with results ($p < 0.001$) indicating it was successful. To test the hypotheses, each model was evaluated through slope analysis (Aiken and West, 1991; Hayes and Matthes, 2009) for a significant three-way interaction between one of the TPB predictors, involvement with the advertisement (INV_{AD}) and the message manipulation. In this way, the statistical model takes the form of a linear equation, which can be expressed as follows:

$$Y = b_0 + b_1X + b_2W + b_3Z + b_4XW + b_5XZ + b_6WZ + b_7XWZ + e$$

where XWZ represents the three-way interaction between the independent variables. By inserting the variables of interest for this study (Sun and Govind, 2017), the equations read:

$$DI = b_0 + b_1ATB + b_2INV_{AD} + b_3MANIP + b_4ATB*INV_{AD} + b_5ATB*MANIP + b_6INV_{AD}*MANIP + b_7ATB*INV_{AD}*MANIP + e \quad (1)$$

$$DI = b_0 + b_1SN + b_2INV_{AD} + b_3MANIP + b_4SN*INV_{AD} + b_5SN*MANIP + b_6INV_{AD}*MANIP + b_7SN*INV_{AD}*MANIP + e \quad (2)$$

$$DI = b_0 + b_1PBC + b_2INV_{AD} + b_3MANIP + b_4PBC*INV_{AD} + b_5PBC*MANIP + b_6INV_{AD}*MANIP + b_7PBC*INV_{AD}*MANIP + e \quad (3)$$

where DI denotes donation intention, INV_{AD} denotes involvement with the advertisement, MANIP is the manipulation, ATB is the attitude toward the behaviour, SN denotes subjective norms and PBC is perceived behavioural control. Additional equations were analysed using donation amount (DAmt) replacing donation intention as the dependent variable while maintaining all independent variables from equations (1)–(3). Analysis was conducted using the PROCESS macro for probing interactions in OLS and logistic regression (Hayes, 2012). This was leveraged because the independent variables were a combination of continuous (TPB and involvement) and categorical (message type). Testing a moderation hypothesis involving continuous variables or between a continuous and a dichotomous variable, using linear regression analysis “allows the effect of X on Y to vary linearly with the moderator” (Hayes and Montoya, 2017, p. 2). Results of this analysis can be found in Table 2.

Attitude toward the behaviour proved to be the best predictor of all the independent variables, being involved in significant three-way interactions with the advertisement type and INV_{AD} for both donation intention ($R^2 = 0.514$, $F(1,273) = 22.97$, $t = -2.39$, $p = 0.017$)

Table 2.
Three-way
interaction results –
Study 1

<i>Model</i>	<i>Dependent variable</i>	<i>B</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>R</i> ²	<i>F</i>	<i>t-value</i>	<i>p-value</i> (<i>Interaction</i>)
1	DV: Donation intention IV: ATB INV _{AD} MANIP	−0.189	0.079	0.514	22.967	−2.394	0.017*
2	DV: Donation Amount IV: ATB INV _{AD} MANIP	−7.342	3.790	0.187	4.993	−1.937	0.043*
4	DV: Donation Intention IV: SN INV _{AD} MANIP	−0.122	0.074	0.512	22.773	−1.640	0.102
5	DV: Donation Amount IV: SN INV _{AD} MANIP	−4.585	3.570	0.182	4.843	−1.284	0.200
7	DV: Donation Intention IV: PBC INV _{AD} MANIP	−0.040	0.109	0.513	22.907	−0.364	0.716
8	DV: Donation Amount IV: PBC INV _{AD} MANIP	−4.387	5.219	0.188	5.042	−0.841	0.401

Notes: ****p* < 0.001; ***p* < 0.01; **p* < 0.05

and donation amount ($R^2 = 0.187$, $F(1,273) = 4.99$, $t = -1.84$, $p = 0.043$). These results provide initial support for *H1a*. Because neither subjective norms nor perceived behavioural control were significant as part of a three-way interaction with the advertisement type and involvement, *H1b* and *H1c* are not supported and neither was analysed going forward. Likewise, neither attitude toward charities nor environmental concern were significant covariates and were not part of the remaining analysis.

To further test the hypotheses, the two models showing significant three-way interactions were analysed using the PROCESS macro to check for significant two-way interactions between attitude toward the behaviour and INV_{AD} for those who saw the high injunctive norm message versus those who saw the low injunctive norm message. This analysis evaluates lower-level confidence intervals (LLCI) and upper-level confidence intervals (ULCI) at one standard deviation less than and one standard deviation more than, the mean. Significance is demonstrated if the confidence intervals do not cross zero (Hayes, 2012). Statistical equations (Hayes and Matthes, 2009) for analysis in this research are:

$$DI = b_0 + b_1ATB + b_2INV_{AD} + b_3ATB * INV_{AD} + e \tag{4}$$

$$DAmt = b_0 + b_1ATB + b_2INV_{AD} + b_3ATB * INV_{AD} + e \tag{5}$$

Results indicate that type of injunctive norm message had a significant effect on the interaction of attitude toward the behaviour and INV_{AD} for both donation intention

($t = 3.488$; $p < 0.001$; LLCI = 0.1751, ULCI = 0.6039) and donation amount ($t = 2.240$; $p = 0.027$; LLCI = 0.1369, ULCI = 24.5958) when individuals viewed the high injunctive norm message, but not when they viewed the low injunctive norm message ($p > 0.05$). That is, individuals high in attitude toward the behaviour had a greater response to the high injunctive norm messages than those who are low when their involvement with the ad is high rather than when their involvement is low (Figure 2). Results were similar for the model with donation amount as the dependent variable when comparing high versus low INV_{AD} (Figure 3), thus *H1a* is supported (Table 3). In addition, the main effect was found for involvement in the low injunctive condition for donation intention [$F(5,125) = 19.707$, $t = -1.257$, $p < 0.106$].

In sum, these results help demonstrate that injunctive norm messages may significantly affect the intended donation behaviour of individuals who are pre-disposed to donating, but only if they are highly involved with the advertisement. When not involved, donations decrease when messages indicate others support the cause. This lack of involvement may be a case of learned helplessness, cognitive exhaustion or simply donor fatigue – all of which could be the result of the growth of the nonprofit sector and the accompanying marketing. The purpose of Study 2, then, is to determine if involvement with the ad has similar effects when the messages change from one of normative injunction to one of social legitimisation.

Results and analysis – Study 2

Study 2 followed a similar procedure as Study 1 except that a social legitimisation of minimal giving message was manipulated instead of the injunctive norm message, with one group seeing the “even a penny” message and the other group seeing no such message. The experiment was another 2 (ATB/SN/PBC: high vs low) $\times$ 2 (social legitimisation: present vs absent) $\times$ 2 (involvement: high vs low) between-subjects design. In total, 302 respondents participated in Study 2 using the same instrument from Study 1 and collecting data online via a nationwide research firm that randomly and evenly distributed participants into the two message manipulations. After removing invalid or incomplete responses, a final sample of 270 individuals (89.4%) was used in the analysis, of which 51.1% ($n = 139$) saw the “even a penny” manipulation and were of age ($M = 44.8$, $SD = 15.39$) and gender (47.8%

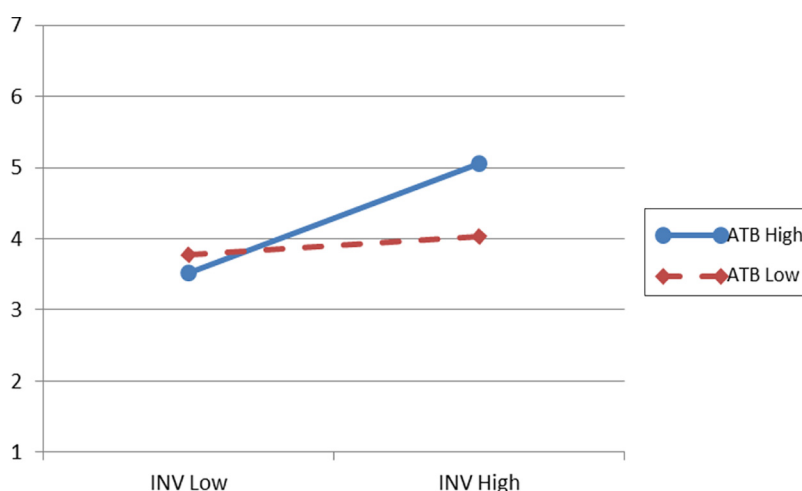
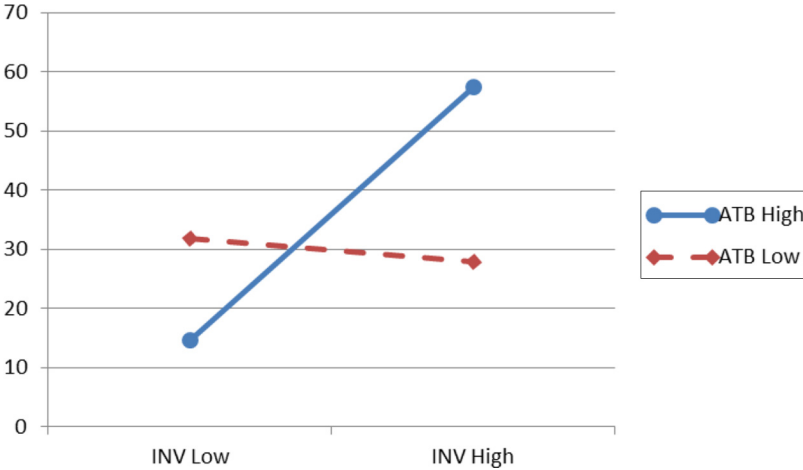


Figure 2. Interaction of ATB and INV_{ad} for high IN message on donation intention

Figure 3.
Interaction of ATB
and INVad for high
IN message on the
donation amount



male) similar to the subjects from the pre-test and Study 1. A one-way ANOVA evaluated the manipulation, with results ($p < 0.001$) indicating it was successful.

As was done in Study 1, each model was evaluated using the PROCESS macro for a significant three-way interaction between one of the TPB predictors, involvement with the advertisement (INV_{AD}) and the message manipulation through regression analysis. Of the models analysed to test the hypotheses, two had significant three-way interactions: subjective norms with INV_{AD} and advertisement type on donation intention ($R^2 = 0.514$, $F(9,260) = 71.477$, $t = 2.166$, $p = 0.031$) and perceived behavioural control on donation intention ($R^2 = 0.187$, $F(9,260) = 71.477$, $t = 2.166$, $p = 0.007$). Unlike Study 1, attitude toward the behaviour was not a good predictor for behavioural intention, thus $H2a$ is not supported. However, these results provide initial support for $H2b$ and $H2c$ (Table 4). Again, neither covariate was significant, and therefore was not part of the remaining analysis.

The data were again analysed using the PROCESS macro for significant two-way interactions between the significant TPB predictors (subjective norms and perceived behavioural control) and INV_{AD} . Interestingly, results from the model featuring the interaction of social legitimisation messages and INV_{AD} were the opposite of what was predicted. That is,

Table 3.
Interaction results by
injunctive norm
message – Study 1

Dependent variable	Group		n	B	SE	R ²	F	t-value	p-value (interaction)
	1 = High IN;	2 = Low IN)							
DV: Donation intention	1	143	0.190	0.054	0.572	46.007	3.488	0.001**	
IV: ATB	2	131	−0.040	0.052	0.441	19.707	−0.764	0.447	
INVad									
ATB* INVad									
DV: Donation amount	1	143	7.191	3.211	0.200	11.523	2.240	0.027*	
IV: ATB	2	131	0.114	1.921	0.100	4.704	0.060	0.953	
INVad									
ATB* INVad									

Notes: *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$

Model	Variables	B	SE	R ²	F	t-value	p-value (Interaction)
1	DV: Donation intention IV: ATB INVad MANIP	0.074	0.054	0.684	62.578	1.357	0.176
2	DV: Donation amount IV: ATB INVad MANIP	-2.364	9.378	0.079	0.252	-0.074	0.801
4	DV: Donation intention IV: SN INVad MANIP	0.092	0.042	0.712	71.477	2.166	0.031*
5	DV: Donation amount IV: SN INVad MANIP	7.570	7.570	0.0862	2.437	1.000	0.318
7	DV: Donation intention IV: PBC INVad MANIP	0.169	0.062	0.687	63.345	2.726	0.007**
8	DV: Donation amount IV: PBC INVad MANIP	10.755	10.646	0.076	2.371	1.010	0.313

Table 4.
Three-way
interaction results –
Study 2

Notes: *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$

individuals high in subjective norms responded significantly different ($t = 2.764$; $p = 0.007$; LLCI = 0.2066, ULCI = 0.6377) from the low subjective norm individuals for donation intention when social legitimisation was *absent* and INV_{AD} was high rather than when social legitimisation was *present* and INV_{AD} was high (Figure 4), thus $H2b$ is not supported.

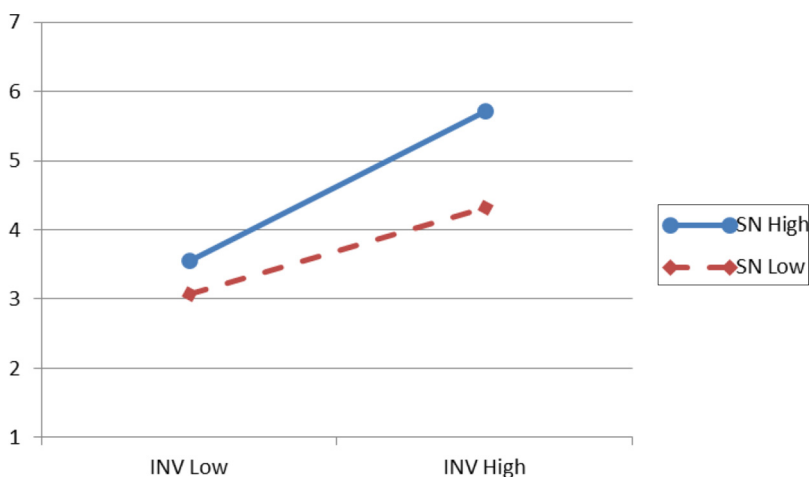


Figure 4.
Interaction of SN and
INVad for a message
without SLM on
donation intention

In addition, main effects were found for the condition where SLM was *present* [$F(4,133) = 67.060, t = 3.757, p < 0.000$], rather than *absent*, the opposite of what was predicted.

Similar results were found for the model with perceived behavioural control as the independent variable in that respondents acted in an opposite fashion to what was expected. Significant differences ($t = 2.111; p = 0.037; LLCI = 0.0084, ULCI = 0.4797$) for donation amount were found under the condition when social legitimisation was *absent* for high INV_{AD} , but not when social legitimisation was *present*, therefore the opposite of what was predicted (Figure 5). Main effects were observed when social legitimisation was *present* [$F(5,132) = 47.414, t = 3.467, p < 0.001$] but not when it was *absent* ($p > 0.05$). These results can be found in Table 5.

The results of Study 2 seem to indicate that the SLM message is an effective tool in nonprofit advertisements only when viewed by individuals who believe they *do not* have the ability to take action. In both instances where perceived behavioural control was part of a significant three-way interaction with INV_{AD} and the type of ad, only when individuals who were low in PBC saw the social legitimisation message did they express a greater behavioural intention than their high PBC counterparts.

It is possible the absence of messages boosting self-efficacy forces individuals to make decisions based solely on their interest in the ad. Those who were involved were more likely to donate when there was no social legitimisation message than when there was. This would seem to indicate that messages justifying minimum giving have a suppressing effect on those who believe they have the ability to give. However, the opposite is true when involvement is low, where the SLM message enhances donations.

General conclusions

The research found that one's involvement with the advertisement combines with one's attitude toward donating (i.e. ATB) to help determine propensity to donate and the amount of the donation. However, this is dependent upon the message in the ad. When messages indicate that others are supportive of the cause, donations increase when one is more involved with the ad and is generally agreeable to donating. But these messages have the opposite effect when one is not involved with the ad – donations decrease when the message indicates others support the cause. And when messages indicate that even a minimal

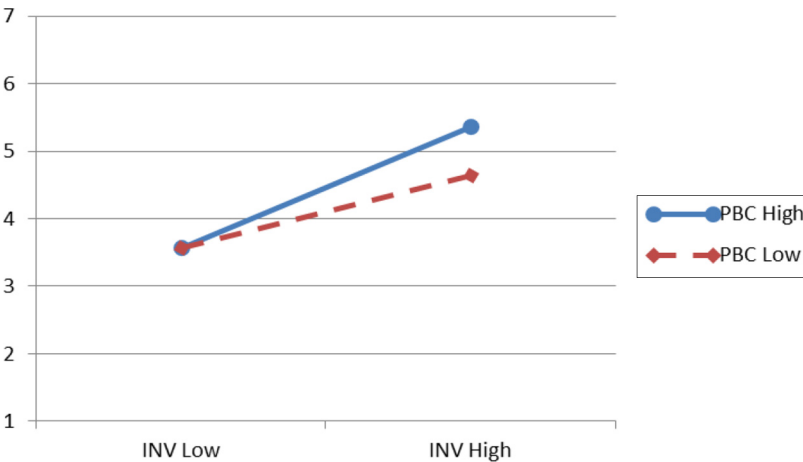


Figure 5.
Interaction of PBC
and INV_{ad} for a
message without
SLM on donation
intention

Dependent variable	Group (1 = SLM present; 2 = SLM absent)	n	B	SE	R ²	F	t-value	p-value (Interaction)
DV: Donation intention	1	138	-0.009	0.032	0.669	67.060	-0.281	0.779
IV: SN	2	132	0.089	0.032	0.681	53.894	2.764	0.007**
INVad								
SN* INVad								
DV: Donation intention	1	138	-0.081	0.053	0.642	47.414	-1.530	0.129
IV: PBC	2	132	0.081	0.039	0.664	49.770	2.111	0.037*
INVad								
PBC* INVad								

Notes: *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$

Table 5.
Interaction results by
social legitimisation
message – Study 2

donation is possible, the attitude driver has no effect on intended donation behaviour. This is consistent with previous findings because peripheral cues are typically more persuasive than rational arguments for individuals who have low involvement with the ad (Amichai-Hamburger *et al.*, 2003).

For individuals who tend to rely on referents for their own actions (i.e. SN), differing messages in advertisements have little effect whether they are involved with the ad or not. That is, in most cases, only their involvement with the ad seems to be the real indicator of behaviour. That said, the message that indicates that minimum giving is acceptable (i.e. SLM) seems to affect donations, as individuals more prone to seek referent input rely on this message to help direct behaviour. But, the cues were more readily adopted by those who were not highly involved. These results are similar to studies (Dibble *et al.*, 2011; Takada and Levine, 2007) that showed when it came to volunteerism, there were no differences between behavioural intention whether simply asking for help or couching it by requesting that an individual perform the bare minimum.

Finally, whether one believes they have the ability to donate (i.e. PBC) can be affected by SLM messages indicating minimal gifts are acceptable. Therefore, individuals who do not believe they can make a gift are more persuaded by messages that make it possible for small donations. When such messages do not exist, however, individuals are likely to donate only when they are highly involved with the ad. That is, the absence of messages boosting self-efficacy forces individuals to make decisions based solely on their interest in the ad. Those who were involved were more likely to donate when there was no SLM message than when there was. This would seem to indicate that messages justifying minimum giving have a dampening effect on those who believe they have the ability to give. However, the opposite is true when involvement is low, where the SLM message increases donations. This may simply be a case of individuals considering a simple way to participate when they do not believe they can do much to help. Because they do not have self-efficacy for the task, messages that demonstrate the ease of participation increase their intention to do so.

Theoretical contributions

This research makes theoretical contributions to three areas:

- (1) nonprofit advertising;
- (2) information processing; and
- (3) behavioural intention.

It does so by integrating message framing, attitudes and beliefs, injunctive norms, self-regulation and advertising response literature to examine the effects of normative and legitimisation messages on individual responses to advertisements. For example, the present investigation contributes to our understanding of the linkage between participation and donations to nonprofits by investigating how injunctive norm messaging that references other supportive participants relate to intended donations (Kim *et al.*, 2021). In addition, the current study responds to the call by Lay *et al.* (2020) for more research that investigates how messaging that uses injunctive norms shape donation responses. Similarly, Bradford (2021, p. 415) suggests that:

Given the deficits faced by most nonprofits, it may be worthwhile to examine which types of reframing are most helpful. For example, the researchers could examine how opportunities for donation might be reframed and what types of resources are most useful for nonprofits and individuals in conducting such reframing.

This research did so by manipulating messages in broadcast quality nonprofit advertisements.

The present research also contributes by responding to calls for further investigations into how marketing messages can be developed that advance the welfare of society through charitable donations (Zhang *et al.*, 2021). In addition to simply demonstrating message effectiveness, this research helped clarify how key variables come together to affect message processing to deepen our understanding of intended donation behaviour. It also sheds light on the current understanding of the central and peripheral routes of the ELM by focussing on the preexisting characteristics of information recipients through TPB. The goal was to learn how preexisting attitudes and beliefs toward donating interact with an individual's involvement with a nonprofit advertisement and what effects the interplay between these constructs has on intent to donate. Integrating two theories, as was done here, can provide better answers to such research questions (Mayer and Sparrowe, 2013).

In making these contributions, this research addresses the request from Chang and Lee (2010) for theoretical advancement through studies that combine prosocial causes, media presentation and giving opportunities to explain how individuals behave differently based on level of involvement. It also responds to the call from Dann *et al.* (2007) to expand the research in philanthropy, gift-giving and fundraising and answered the challenge from Grau and Folse (2007) to explore factors such as consumer traits and campaign structural elements that may impact consumer involvement in nonprofit marketing campaigns and affect the process mechanisms responsible for behaviour. Likewise, the research responds to the suggestion by Tangari *et al.* (2010) that researchers should examine the effects of ad processing and message framing on self-regulation, where consumers use internal and external cues to affect behaviour in situations where they consider social norms (Bandura, 1986, 1991). This was done by leveraging the predictive constructs of TPB related to attitude and subjective norms that constitute internal cues, while the advertising message functions as the external cue. The research responds to Dunn *et al.*'s (2020) suggestion that research should seek to identify preexisting beliefs that may play an important role in responding to donation opportunities by examining the TPB constructs in a message framing context.

Further, the research joins the recent contributions of Rifkin *et al.* (2021), who have investigated how small donations can be encouraged by testing messages characterised by the social legitimisation of minimum giving. Further, by testing messages characterised by the social legitimisation of minimum giving, the research extends our understanding and

generalisability of such messages. Specifically, [Dibble *et al.* \(2011\)](#) and [Shanahan *et al.* \(2012\)](#) asked for research that could help improve the generalisability of social legitimisation messages by:

- using continuous dependent variables, which this research does for donation intention,
- improving the explanatory power of social legitimisation messages by increasing the sample size from previous research where $N = 63$ ([Takada and Levine, 2007](#)) and $N = 145$ ([Dibble *et al.*, 2011](#)), which was accomplished in this research where $N = 270$ for Study 2.

In answering these calls for more research, the results extend the ELM-TPB integrated model. Firstly, the research shows that ELM has varying utilities and values from TPB in different contexts. While involvement with the advertisement, a construct of ELM, has more explanatory power in most cases, when considered holistically, the explanatory power varies for one person versus another. For example, SLM messages indicating that minimum giving is acceptable seem to affect donations from individuals who are more likely to look to their referents to help direct their behaviour. But, these SLM cues were more readily adopted by those who were *not* highly involved with the advertisement rather than those who were. Similarly, individuals who do not think they have the ability to make a donation (i.e. low self-efficacy) showed an increase in donations when they saw the SLM message and had *low* ad involvement. These results help answer the request from [Xu and Huang \(2020\)](#) for research on potential moderators of framing effects in nonprofit advertising. Still, in general, involvement with the ad was the key to increasing donations more so than preexisting attitudes and beliefs. In reaching this conclusion, the research responds to the suggestion by [Tao *et al.* \(2021\)](#) to develop a better understanding of how varying levels of involvement affect information processing to create more effective donation messaging strategies.

Finally, another goal of this research was to test TPB in an online advertising environment within the context of nonprofit donation. In that regard, the theory performed quite well. Not only did both measured dependent variables – donation intention and donation amount – show some level of significance across four different message treatments, but all three predictors were significant at least once. Thus, TPB performed well in terms of generalisability and showed that the decision to support a nonprofit organisation is an individual choice under the guidance of attitudes, perceived norms and self-efficacy. This helps refute calls ([Sniehotta *et al.*, 2014](#)) to retire the TPB by demonstrating that it is still an efficient tool with explanatory power and supports the meta-analysis by [Steinmetz *et al.* \(2016\)](#) that shows significant effects for TPB-based interventions.

Still, more research is always needed describing how involvement can be used by practitioners to make strategic marketing decisions. One such study did find involvement differences accounted for advertisement effectiveness based on donation proximity and message framing ([Grau and Folse, 2007](#)). However, involvement was conceptualised in terms of involvement with the cause rather than involvement with the ad, as was the case in this research. Still, strategically targeting audiences based on involvement may lead to better fundraising results. Therefore, what nonprofit marketing managers need is the ability to identify the causal antecedents, such as the ones used in this research (attitude toward the behaviour, social norms, perceived behavioural control) and behavioural outcomes (donation intention) to have a better understanding of what audiences to target and what messages to deliver to increase the propensity of affecting their behaviour in a way that is positive to the

organisation. The following managerial implications attempt to provide guidance to practitioners interested in leveraging persuasive communications in three ways:

- (1) identifying their audiences;
- (2) developing marketing strategies; and
- (3) implementing and executing appropriate tactics.

Managerial implications

The results offer nonprofit marketing managers and boards of directors additional insight into various donor groups and how best to increase donations. Based on the results and previous discussion, the following strategies are recommended. Firstly, those who pay attention to the ad and have a positive attitude toward charitable giving are going to donate if they are told that others support the cause. Therefore, special focus should be on those who are not involved with the ad but still believe giving to NPOs is appropriate behaviour. Increasing involvement may turn them from non-donor to donor when accompanied by messages of community support.

Secondly, to increase involvement, marketing managers should focus on execution cues that can motivate audiences to attend to and process the information in the advertisement (Grau and Folse, 2007). Surprise can help engage individuals with a nonprofit (Cockrill and Parsonage, 2016). However, nonprofit marketing managers must also guard against making audiences too uncomfortable, thus risking negative emotional response and leading to antithetical behaviour (Garg and Lerner, 2013; Shanahan *et al.*, 2012). Involvement may also increase through repeated campaign messages and the use of positive, rather than negative, message framing (Grau and Folse, 2007). The key is to make people interested in the advertisement by keeping them off balance, within the appropriateness of the cause. Putting people on edge through the unusual and unexpected gets attention and ultimately, increases audience involvement. Ads by the anti-smoking campaign TheTruth.com may be a good example of a way to accomplish this and have been proven to be a significant factor in declining numbers of smokers (Farrelly *et al.*, 2005). In any situation, marketing managers must be aware that taking a risk with marketing efforts means they are using funds from previous donors to raise money through edgy advertising (West and Sargeant, 2004) and those donors may question the use of their contributions in the face of perceived uncomfortable communications.

Thirdly, when it comes to individuals who look to others for behavioural cues, messages that make minimal participation acceptable have the effect of increasing donations, but only for those who are not involved in the advertisement. Therefore, NPOs should consider the likelihood of their audience being involved in the ad when using this type of message because a social legitimisation message will have a suppressing effect on individuals who are engaged. Public service announcements are often scheduled by broadcasters at times of low viewership, such as after midnight or early Sunday morning, when those who are viewing may not be terribly involved in the advertisement. It is at this time that minimal giving messages might have a positive effect on donations. However, messages indicating minimal *effort* might not be advisable, as research has found that the number of work NPOs requires of the consumer is positively related to greater behavioural orientation (Garretson and Landreth, 2005). Late-night television viewing is also more common among younger audiences and, therefore may offer another justification for using minimum giving messages. The United Way has attempted this with ads that contain messages “Donate \$1” and “Text ‘fit’ to give \$5”. It may be fruitful for future research to investigate the differences

between the effects of messages communicating minimal giving versus those communicating minimal effort and to determine if the combination of the two impacts donations.

Finally, this research indicates those who believe they are not able to contribute are more likely to give when they encounter a message that says the minimum effort is socially acceptable. This is true whether they are involved with the ad or not. But when it comes to those who believe they can contribute, such a message generates varying reactions. It suppresses giving among those paying attention to the ad and enhances giving from those not paying attention. Therefore, marketing managers must be careful about asking regular donors to make minimal gift requests, but should instead save such messages for donor prospects. Because of the growing need for domestic audiences to provide financial assistance to international issues (Moriuchi and Chung, 2018), NPOs that ask potential donors in one country to help individuals in another may consider incorporating this strategy.

Limitations and future research

As with all research, there are limitations to what the results of these studies are able to explain. For example, while some research has shown that consumers are more likely to donate to an individual (Kogut and Ritov, 2011; Small, 2011; Small *et al.*, 2007), other results counter the identifiable victim effect, particularly when the NPO is physically removed from the donor (Ein-Gar and Levontin, 2013). Therefore, the ads in this research could be construed by respondents as either the identifiable victim or the physiologically distant NPO because the organisation was fictitious. Future research could determine the situational influences of nonprofit advertisements featuring an identified victim. Alternative message framing can also be leveraged to address the limitation of viewers interpreting the ad through the lens of either the identifiable victim or the physiologically distant NPO. Specifically, whether the message is framed as promoting altruism through helping others or making oneself feel better through satisfaction has been shown to affect donation behaviour (Nelson *et al.*, 2006). In addition, the strength of the storytelling has an effect on the viewer's perception of the narrative in the advertisement being of a victim or a distant NPO (Chang and Lee, 2010). Future research could examine the congruency of the narrative with the types of messages used in this research – injunctive norms and social legitimisation – because it may increase ad effectiveness, particularly when the story is framed negatively (e.g. “Ricky has a problem”) and has potentially negative outcomes for the protagonist (Smith and Shaffer, 2000).

Other variables that may have affected the results of these studies and are, therefore, potential limitations, include temporal influences such as time of year, environmental variables such as natural disasters and any associated relief efforts and similar campaigns that might increase awareness of the issue and affect toward donating. For example, the tsunami in the Indian Ocean and Hurricane Katrina took place within eight months of one another in 2004–2005 and could have affected donations at that time because of increased awareness of the devastation caused by such natural disasters. In addition, making donations at the end of a calendar year is a “well-established tool” in tax planning (Gill, 2020, p. 34), though data were collected for these studies in the third quarter.

Because involvement was the driver in the integrated ELM-TPB model used in this research, it would be valuable to identify the boundary conditions in which involvement is no longer the primary influence in the individual's behavioural intention. Involvement with the advertisement is just one measure of involvement, however. It would also be beneficial to examine the ELM-TPB model measuring involvement with the cause, conceptualised as the degree to which individuals find the cause to be personally relevant (Grau and Folse, 2007), as a potential moderating variable. In addition, the advertisements featured organisation-

related information, which communicate characteristics of the NPO and the cause it supports and which previous research found has a greater effect on donation amount decisions than behavioural decisions (Fajardo *et al.*, 2018). Therefore, injunctive norm and SLM messages should be tested in donor-related informational ads, communicating intrinsic characteristics of the donor and his or her self-perception, as well.

Also, beliefs and attitudes may function with additional predictor variables to determine behavioural intention. For example, O'Cass and Griffin (2006) have suggested that believability of an advertisement in conjunction with attitude/beliefs could be an important relationship in cause marketing because marketers are attempting to change attitudes as a means of influencing social behaviours. Concepts from symbolic consumption theory may also be at play and should be investigated. While mostly used in research investigating volunteer behaviour (Mitchell and Clark, 2020; Wymer and Samu, 2002), the four functions of symbolic consumption – emblematic, role acquisition, connectedness and expressiveness – may be factors in responding to a donation request in response to an advertising stimulus. There appears to be a need to investigate the concept of social legitimisation messages as well. Because this study and other efforts (Dibble *et al.*, 2011; Goswami and Urminsky, 2016; Takada and Levine, 2007), have failed to show any effects for SLM messages, the call here is to further examine why these types of messages appear to fail in motivating respondents into intentions that indicate behaviour.

Research has found demographic variables such as income (Jones and Posnett, 1991), education (Mears, 1992), age (Peterson *et al.*, 2018) and gender (Nichols, 1998) are strong predictors of donation levels. Therefore, it is possible that demographic variables may serve as moderators similar to how involvement is in this study. That is, if age should be considered when understanding individual responses to persuasive messages as previous research has indicated, what other variables might moderate this integrated theory? Perhaps, gender, religion, education and household income should be closely considered as moderators in an ELM-TPB framework, with one or more potentially showing much more explanatory power than others.

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Appendix 1. Script – nonprofit ad spots (*manipulations shown in italics*)

Text with images

Text: Ricky has a problem. (image 1)

Text: He can't get to school safely.

Text: It's not gangs or drugs that make the route to school unsafe. (image 2)

Text: It's the roads. (image 3, 4)

Text: That's because our cities have been built with one thing in mind. (image 5, 6)

Text: Cars. (image 7)

Text: The result?

Text: Unsafe routes to schools put our children in danger. (image 8, 9)

Text: Pollution from traffic makes asthma worse. (image 10)

Text: impairs lungs, hardens the heart.

Text: and can lead to death.

Voice over with images

VO: "Because of the decline in walking and riding a bike to school, our children have the highest obesity rate in history and breathe more pollution". (image 11, 12)

VO: “As a result, life expectancy for the average American could decline by as much as five years, the first sustained drop in life expectancy in the modern era”. (image 13, 14)

Voice over and text with images

VO: “Do we want our children to be the first ones who don’t live longer than their parents”?

Text: Is this what we want to give our children? (image 15)

VO: “This decline is not inevitable if we make simple improves to the cities in which we live”.

Text: But you can change that.

VO: “The Better Cities Coalition is making infrastructure improvements to our cities all across the country”.

Text: The Better Cities Coalition is making our cities better. (image 16, 17, 18)

VO: “Better parks, better sidewalks and better cities mean healthier and happier people”.

Text: For everyone . . . (image 19, 20)

VO: “Please support the Better Cities Coalition today by making a donation online or volunteering for our Better Block Programme. Americans just as you have responded”. (image 21, 22)

Study 1 manipulation of high (low) injunctive norms

VO: “To date, 73% (29%) of the people where you live are supportive of building better cities”.

Text: To date, 73% (29%) of the people where you live are supportive of building better cities. (image 23)

VO: “Please give to the Better Cities Coalition today”.

Text: Won’t you please donate or volunteer today? (image 24)

Study 2 manipulation of present (absent) social legitimisation

VO: “Even a penny will help”.

Text: Even a penny will help. (image 24)

VO: “Because Ricky is counting on you”.

Text: Ricky is counting on you. (image 1)

VO: “Go to www.BetterCities.org”.

Text: www.BetterCities.org.

VO: “And help us make life better, for everyone”. (image 25)

Text: bettercities.org.

Text: making life better for everyone.

Appendix 2. Donation intention (Fishbein and Ajzen, 2010)

Based on the advertisement I just saw, by donating to the Better Cities Coalition would be:

- unlikely/likely,
- non-existent/existent,
- improbable/probable,
- impossible/possible,
- uncertain/certain,
- definitely yes/definitely no, (r)
- not at all/very frequent,
- no chance/certain chance,
- probably/probably not. (r)

Donation amount

If you were to make a donation to this nonprofit, how much would give?

Attitude toward the behaviour (Fishbein and Ajzen, 2010)

My donating to a nonprofit organisation would be:

- bad/good,
- pleasant/unpleasant, (r)
- valuable/worthless, (r)
- important/unimportant, (r)
- worthless/worthwhile,
- lousy/nice,
- useless/useful,
- unpleasant/enjoyable,
- satisfying/unrewarding, (r)
- pointless/meaningful,
- rewarding/ungratifying. (r)

Subjective norms (Fishbein and Ajzen, 2010)

- (1) Most people who are important to me approve of my donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year.
- (2) Most people like me donated to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the past year.
- (3) It is expected of me that I donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year.
- (4) Most people whose opinions I value donated to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the past year.

Perceived behavioural control (Fishbein and Ajzen, 2010)

- (1) I am confident that if I wanted to I could donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year.
- (2) My donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is completely up to me.
- (3) I have complete control over whether or not I donate to a nonprofit organisation.
- (4) Donating to a nonprofit organisation is beyond my capabilities. (r)
- (5) For me to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is extremely difficult/extremely easy.

Involvement with the ad (Cox and Cox, 2001)

- (1) I got involved in what the ad had to say.
- (2) The message seemed relevant to me.
- (3) This ad really made me think.
- (4) This ad was thought-provoking.
- (5) The Better Cities Coalition was very interesting.
- (6) I felt strong emotions while watching this ad.

Attitude toward charitable organisations (webb *et al.*, 2000)

Preexisting
beliefs

- (1) The money given to charities goes for good causes.
- (2) Much of the money donated to charities is wasted. (r)
- (3) My image of charitable organisations is positive.
- (4) Charitable organisations have been quite successful in helping the needy.
- (5) Charity organisations perform a useful function for society.

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Environmental concern (Weigel and Weigel, 1978)

- (1) The federal government will have to introduce harsh measures to halt pollution, as few people will regulate themselves.
- (2) We should not worry about killing too many game animals because in the long run things will balance out. (r)
- (3) I'd be willing to make personal sacrifices for the sake of slowing down pollution even though the immediate results may not seem significant.
- (4) Pollution is *not* personally affecting my life. (r)
- (5) The benefits of modern consumer products are more important than the pollution that results from their production and use. (r)
- (6) We must prevent any type of animal from becoming extinct, even if it means sacrificing some things for ourselves.
- (7) A course focussing on the conservation of natural resources should be taught in public schools.
- (8) Although there is continual contamination of our lakes, streams and air, nature's purifying process soon returns to normal. (r)
- (9) Because the government has such good inspecting and control agencies, it's very unlikely that pollution due to energy production will become excessive. (r)
- (10) The government should provide each citizen with a list of agencies and organisations to which citizens could report grievances concerning pollution.
- (11) Predators such as hawks, crows, skunks and coyotes with prey on farmers' grain crops and poultry should be eliminated. (r)
- (12) The currently active anti-pollution organisations are really more interested in disrupting society than they are in fighting pollution. (r)
- (13) Even if public transportation was more efficient than it is, I would prefer to drive my car to work. (r)
- (14) Industry is trying its best to develop effective anti-pollution technology. (r)
- (15) If asked, I would contribute time, money or both to an organisation like the Sierra Club that works to improve the quality of the environment.

Manipulation check-in message ads

- (1) Recalling the advertisement you saw, how would you rate the number of people who have donated to the Better Cities Coalition?
- (2) Recalling the advertisement you saw, the amount of people who are supportive of donating to the Better Cities Coalition is high.
- (3) Based on the advertisement I saw, I have no idea how supportive people are of the Better Cities Coalition. (r)

Manipulation check – social legitimisation of the minimum message ads

Recalling the advertisement you saw, a minimal amount can be donated to the Better Cities Coalition.

Recalling the advertisement you saw, it is OK to donate the bare minimum to the Better Cities Coalition.

Based on the advertisement you saw, making a minimal donation to the Better Cities Coalition is not acceptable. (r)

Appendix 3

Table A1.
Donation intention – Study 1

Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1. Unlikely/likely	0.937	0.962
2. Non-existent/existent	0.922	
3. Improbable/probable	0.937	
4. Impossible/possible	0.688	
5. Uncertain/certain	0.843	
6. Definitely yes/definitely no	0.824	
7. Not at all/very frequent	0.898	
8. No chance/certain chance	0.930	

Table A2.
Behavioural intention – Study 1

Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1. I plan to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.968	0.971
2. I will make an effort to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.957	
3. The chances of me donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is:	0.947	
4. I intend to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.971	

			Preexisting beliefs
Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha	
1. Bad/good	0.702	0.948	
2. Pleasant/unpleasant	0.811		
3. Valuable/worthless	0.821		
4. Important/unimportant	0.849		
5. Worthless/worthwhile	0.856		
6. Lousy/nice	0.822		
7. Useless/useful	0.862		
8. Unpleasant/enjoyable	0.785		
9. Satisfying/unrewarding	0.861		
10. Pointless/meaningful	0.829		
11. Rewarding/ungratifying	0.816		

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Table A3.

Attitude toward the behaviour – Study 1

Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha	
1. Most people who are important to me approve of my donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.741	0.804	
2. Most people like me donated to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the past year	0.817		
3. It is expected of me that I donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.751		
4. Most people whose opinions I value donated to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the past year	0.881		

Table A4.

Subjective norms – Study 1

Table A5.
Perceived
behavioural control –
Study 1

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1.	I am confident that if I wanted to I could donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.754	0.813
2.	My donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is completely up to me	0.847	
3.	I have complete control over whether or not I donate to a nonprofit organisation	0.829	
4.	Donating to a nonprofit organisation is beyond my capabilities	0.595	
5.	For me to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is:	0.592	

Table A6.
Involvement with the
ad – Study 1

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1.	I got involved in what the ad had to say	0.899	0.949
2.	The message seemed relevant to me	0.897	
3.	This ad really made me think	0.928	
4.	This ad was thought-provoking	0.919	
5.	The Better Cities Coalition was very interesting	0.910	
6.	I felt strong emotions while watching this ad	0.805	

Table A7.
Attitude toward
charitable
organisations –
Study 1

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1.	The money given to charities goes for good causes	0.895	0.839
2.	Much of the money donated to charity is wasted	0.914	
3.	My image of charitable organisations is positive	0.480	
4.	Charitable organisations have been quite successful in helping the needy	0.871	
5.	Charity organisations perform a useful function for society	0.836	

			Preexisting beliefs
Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha	
1. The federal government will have to introduce harsh measures to halt pollution, as few people will regulate themselves	0.695	0.865	247
2. We should not worry about killing too many game animals because in the long run things will balance out	0.686		
3. I'd be willing to make personal sacrifices for the sake of slowing down pollution even though the immediate results may not seem significant	0.704		
4. Pollution is <i>not</i> personally affecting my life	0.684		
5. The benefits of modern consumer products are more important than the pollution that results from their production and use	0.731		
6. We must prevent any type of animal from becoming extinct, even if it means sacrificing some things for ourselves	0.691		
7. A course focussing on the conservation of natural resources should be taught in public schools	0.797		
8. Although there is continual contamination of our lakes, streams and air, nature's purifying process soon returns them to normal	0.769		
9. Because the government has such good inspecting and control agencies, it's very unlikely that pollution due to energy production will become excessive	0.773		
10. The government should provide each citizen with a list of agencies and organisations to which citizens could report grievances concerning pollution	0.729		
11. Predators such as hawks, crows, skunks and coyotes which prey on farmers' grain crops and poultry should be eliminated	0.648		
12. The currently active anti-pollution organisations are really more interested in disrupting society than they are in fighting pollution	0.463		
13. Even if public transportation was more efficient than it is, I would prefer to drive my car to work	0.675		
14. Industry is trying its best to develop effective anti-pollution technology	0.817		
15. If asked, I would contribute time, money or both to an organisation like the Sierra Club that works to improve the quality of the environment	0.772		
			Table A8. Environmental concern – Study 1

Table A9.
Donation intention –
Study 2

Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1. Unlikely/likely	0.924	0.970
2. Non-existent/existent	0.946	
3. Improbable/probable	0.935	
4. Impossible/possible	0.777	
5. Uncertain/certain	0.879	
6. Definitely yes/definitely no	0.859	
7. Not at all/very frequent	0.910	
8. No chance/certain chance	0.931	
9. Probably/probably not	0.915	

Table A10.
Behavioural
intention – Study 2

Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1. I plan to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.954	0.964
2. I will make an effort to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.949	
3. The chances of me donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is:	0.937	
4. I intend to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.964	

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha	Preexisting beliefs
1.	Bad/good	0.805	0.959	249
2.	Pleasant/unpleasant	0.805		
3.	Valuable/worthless	0.828		
4.	Important/unimportant	0.902		
5.	Worthless/worthwhile	0.891		
6.	Lousy/nice	0.872		
7.	Useless/useful	0.898		
8.	Unpleasant/enjoyable	0.888		
9.	Satisfying/unrewarding	0.810		
1.	Pointless/meaningful	0.862	0.737	Table A11. Attitude towards the behaviour – Study 2
1.	Rewarding/ungratifying	0.737		

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha	
1.	Most people who are important to me approve of my donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.771	0.824	Table A12. Subjective norms – Study 2
2.	Most people like me donated to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the past year	0.815		
3.	It is expected of me that I donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.772		
4.	Most people whose opinions I value donated to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the past year	0.890		

Table A13.
Perceived
behavioural control –
Study 2

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1.	I am confident that if I wanted to I could donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year	0.755	0.835
2.	My donating to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is completely up to me	0.853	
3.	I have complete control over whether or not I donate to a nonprofit organisation	0.838	
4.	Donating to a nonprofit organisation is beyond my capabilities	0.619	
5.	For me to donate to a nonprofit organisation sometime in the next year is:	0.632	

Table A14.
Involvement with the
ad – Study 2

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1.	I got involved in what the ad had to say	0.892	0.953
2.	The message seemed relevant to me	0.890	
3.	This ad really made me think	0.940	
4.	This ad was thought-provoking	0.900	
5.	The Better Cities Coalition was very interesting	0.932	
6.	I felt strong emotions while watching this ad	0.847	

Table A15.
Attitude toward
charitable
organisations –
Study 2

Item		Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha
1.	The money given to charities goes for good causes	0.873	0.886
2.	Much of the money donated to charity is wasted	0.839	
3.	Charitable organisations have been quite successful in helping the needy	0.871	
4.	Charity organisations perform a useful function for society	0.871	

			Preexisting beliefs
Item	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha	
1. The federal government will have to introduce harsh measures to halt pollution, as few people will regulate themselves	0.714	0.720	251
2. We should not worry about killing too many game animals because in the long run things will balance out	0.773		
3. I'd be willing to make personal sacrifices for the sake of slowing down pollution even though the immediate results may not seem significant			
4. Pollution is <i>not</i> personally affecting my life	0.736		
5. The benefits of modern consumer products are more important than the pollution that results from their production and use	0.803		
6. We must prevent any type of animal from becoming extinct, even if it means sacrificing some things for ourselves	0.745		
7. A course focussing on the conservation of natural resources should be taught in public schools	0.769		
8. Although there is continual contamination of our lakes, streams and air, nature's purifying process soon returns them to normal	0.784		
9. Because the government has such good inspecting and control agencies, it's very unlikely that pollution due to energy production will become excessive	0.779		
10. The government should provide each citizen with a list of agencies and organisations to which citizens could report grievances concerning pollution	0.674		
11. Predators such as hawks, crows, skunks and coyotes which prey on farmers' grain crops and poultry should be eliminated	0.653		
			Table A16. Environmental concern – Study 2

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